Bureau (IB), the inspector general of the Chandigarh Police and the advocate general of Punjab were all present that evening. In the recent past, the government of Punjab had developed a strategy of cultivating the media for better press, in order to secure more favourable coverage of its response to the separatist movement.[2] In step with this strategy, Kapur had also invited a group of journalists (including from the *Hindustan Times*, the *Indian Express*, the Press Trust of India and *India Today*) to the party.

Among the most high-profile attendees that evening was K.P.S. Gill, director general of the Punjab Police. Gill had acquired the reputation of being an uncompromising and ruthless police officer, and was tasked with addressing the widespread violence in the state. As one scholar noted, Gill 'offered the terrorists a stark choice: they could either die for their idea of God, or live for themselves. There was no third option.'[3] He had just come off a resounding success in Operation Black Thunder, in which a large group of terrorists was cleared from the Golden Temple in Amritsar.

Rupan Deol Bajaj and her husband B.R. Bajaj, both senior IAS officers of the Punjab cadre, arrived at the Kapur residence at about 9 p.m. The guests were seated in the lawn at the back of the house. As was customary, cane chairs were arranged to form two semicircles facing one another – the men would sit in one of the semicircles and the women in the other. About an hour later, Gill walked over to the women's semicircle, and occupied a vacant chair about five to six seats away from Mrs Bajaj. Many of the women seated around Gill happened to be rising from their seats and entering the house around that time. Gill called out to Bajaj, and asked her to sit on the vacant chair next to him. He pulled the chair closer to his as Bajaj was about to sit down. Bajaj pulled the chair back to its original position, but Gill repeated the gesture. Realizing that 'something was very wrong',[4] Bajaj returned to her original seat between two women in the semicircle.

A few minutes later, Gill approached and stood directly in front of Bajaj – so close that his legs were about four inches from her knees. Crooking his finger, he demanded that she stand up and come along with him. By this time, the other women in the semicircle were 'shocked and speechless'.[5]